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ENTERTAINMENT

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DUTCH DOSCHER For The Times

"IT'S not about shock," Peaches says of her work. "It's about provoking. For reasons." She's currently touring her seventh album.

She just can't be squashed

Powerhouse provocateur Peaches has a new album that's crude, smart and disarming, with a touch of grief

BY KATHERINE TURMAN

At a corner table on the expansive patio of a trendy Frogtown restaurant, Peaches' blue eyes focus on the hovering waiter. "The vodka is gonna be rested on oyster shells," he proffers. "It's kind of inheriting that briny character, like a martini of the sea."

"Lovely, great. Love it," Peaches says quickly.

"Two of those, perfect," the waiter replies.

Peaches is, as she sings in her new song "Panna Cotta Delight," "a woman in control of all her holes," and mistress of a creative life where nothing appears outside of the realm of possibility. She's collaborated or toured with Yoko Ono, Marilyn Manson and Iggy Pop, among more underground artists (NYC "drag terrorist" Christeene, the spirit "entity" the Squirt Deluxe) across genres and countries and languages (Yiddish, Italian). But it's Peaches' own music and stage show — ugly-beautiful DIY aesthetics and pulsing electroclash musi-

[See **Peaches,** E8]

Where Bluey goes to play

The popular animated dog and her sister star in a live experience at Disneyland Resort.

BY TODD MARTENS

Animated Australian sensation "Bluey" has arrived in Disneyland, and the titular anthropomorphic pastel-coated canine has come ready to play. And dance. And to race some "barky boats."

The Walt Disney Co. first teased that the blue heeler puppy and her younger sister Bingo would be coming to the Anaheim theme park in 2024. Bluey is now the star of a performance-focused takeover of the park's Fantasyland Theatre, which officially opened Sunday.

Two shows, games and spontaneous dance parties are hallmarks of the experience, as Disneyland's live entertainment team sought to translate the show's particular broadcast-based appeal to the real world.

"Bluey" works because it's charmed children and grown-ups alike, emphasizing imaginative parenting skills as much as it does Bluey's playful spirit. Though only about seven minutes, each core "Bluey" episode unfolds patiently, often centered on make-believe, wonder and childlike ingenuity. Subtle life

[See **Bluey,** E2]

MARK POTTS Los Angeles Times

BINGO, left, and Bluey star in "Bluey's Best Day Ever!" at Disneyland.

Artist Banksy's ID is revealed

Debate has followed on whether his works, long associated with his mystique, will now lose their value. **E3**

An unexpected rescue story

The film "Miroirs No. 3" follows the survivor of a car accident who finds comfort with a roadside stranger. **E3**

Comics **E6-7**
Puzzles **E7**

Eric Idle reintroduces 'Spamalot'

As the stage revival gallops into Pantages, the comedian is feeling sentimental.

BY MALIA MENDEZ

The last time Eric Idle's "Monty Python and the Holy Grail" spoof musical "Spamalot" landed at a major L.A. venue a decade ago, he played the show's tweedy historian, who sets the scene for the Arthurian legend with a seriousness entirely unfit for the absurdist romp to follow.

It was a perfect role for the "Monty Python's Flying Circus" alum, to whom dry humor comes as naturally as breathing.

But when "Spamalot"

[See **Idle,** E8]

JASON ARMOND Los Angeles Times

FINGERS CROSSED that Idle doesn't meet the Killer Rabbit of Caerbannog.

'NCIS' hits a milestone with no plans to ease up

Careful thought went into this week's 500th episode, a mark of the series' long reach.

BY JIM HALTERMAN

We're used to seeing the intrepid team of naval special agents on CBS' crime procedural "NCIS" working together to solve the toughest cases and bring down the worst villains. But even they may be stumped when faced with the gargantuan challenge of coming up with a deserving story to encapsulate the unique feat of producing 500 episodes of television.

But the team can rest easy since that job fell to "NCIS" showrunner and executive producer Steven D. Binder, who wrote Tuesday's episode, "All Good Things" (with José Clemente Hernandez directing). He shares that ideas began popping up in his mind when the show's 22nd season was wrapping up last year. "I started thinking 'What questions should I be asking?' I knew it had to be something big that resonates with the fans and should be worthy of the 500th," he says.

With its 500th episode, the hit show will rank among the longest-running scripted, live-action American prime-time series, behind "Law & Order: Special Victims Unit" and "Law & Order." But how "NCIS" began its journey to this rare

[See **'NCIS,'** E2]

‘Bluey’s’ live experience features two shows

[**Bluey,** from E1]
lessons, such as cooperation, understanding one’s self-worth, overcoming a fear of the unknown and much more, dot seemingly simple scenarios.

In many episodes, Bluey’s mom (Chilli) and dad (Bandit) indulge in their daughters’ penchant to play pretend, so much so that a friend of mine with a young girl joked that she needed to watch the show to learn how to be a better mom.

I arrived at “Bluey’s Best Day Ever!” as a childless columnist, and yet I came away enchanted by what Disneyland’s live entertainment team, led by Susana Tubert, had concocted. It’s a little silly and corny, yes, but manages to vary the tempo and can even tug at one’s heartstrings by showing the bond between siblings.

Theme park fare, especially when aimed at a preschool set, tends to fall back on high-energy, photo-op-based treatments, and while there’s plenty of amped-up goofiness here, “Bluey’s Best Day Ever!” understands that’s not why the series was the most-streamed program in 2025, according to data from research firm Nielsen.

Two core shows are featured in the experience, and some “Bluey” regulars appear. The overbearing hand-puppet Unicorse plays key roles in launching each performance. Set to play continuously throughout the day, with breaks for Bluey and Bingo to appear on stage and dance or play with youngsters, each has a slightly different tone and feel.

One emphasizes an adventure story, its themes encouraging Bluey to flash some bravery and dispel stereotypes. The other takes a lighter touch, with some of the softer, almost ballad-like songs from the show, such as “Rain (Boldly in the Pretend),” highlighted, seeking to emphasize the bond between Bluey and Bingo. Here, I thought of Bluey’s more tender moments — those, for instance, that emphasize becoming comfortable with growing older and letting go.

MARK POTTS Los Angeles Times

“BLUEY’S BEST DAY EVER!” includes shows, puppets, live music, dancing and “barky boat” racing.

“We try to hit the humor, the play — shared play — and some of the more profound experiences that these characters go through,” Tubert says. “At the end of the second show, you’ll see a moment that is really quite beautiful. It’s a tribute to sisterhood, and how these two characters of Bluey and Bingo connect with one another.”

While one can certainly sit in the Fantasyland Theatre’s stands and simply take in the two shows, there are plenty of moments geared at getting audiences moving. Dances may mimic animal behaviors, or reference popular moments from the series, such as getting grannies to floss.

A nod to the attention-seeking fairies — here, less Tinker Bell and more a metaphor for being noticed — inspires a “Riverdance”-like breakout. The five-piece, brass-heavy band gets a workout when Bluey’s impossible-to-control toy Chattermax has a cameo. The squawking plaything can test even Bluey’s patience.

Throughout, performers walk a line between teaching the maneuvers to the crowd and getting lost in the moment themselves. The challenge for Disney choreographer Taylor Worden was to create dance moves that also doubled as audience encouragement.

Spin, for instance, like a flower in the wind, or lightly snap your fingers to recall the sound of rain. Bounce with your hands in front of you as if you’re driving a car down a rocky street, or put your hand above your head and try for an elegant, ballerina-inspired twirl.

“It actually was letting go of all of those technical things that I’ve learned and letting that inner child come out,” Worden says. “As imaginative as Bluey and Bingo are, I wanted to hone in on that. I want everybody to enjoy, have fun and play. Play is at the forefront of everything. It’s so easy to get set in our ways, and even as an adult, it’s so hard to actually play nowadays. This has been such an experience to get to a childlike state.”

There’s more, however, to “Bluey’s Best Day Ever!” than the two performances. The Fantasyland Theatre has been outfitted with pop-up installations. Some are purely photo ops, such as an opportunity for little ones to take a class photo with Bluey and her pals, while others aim to inspire exploration, such as a mini gnome village or fairy garden.

Taken as a whole, the feel is something of a fair, like hanging out with Bluey and Bingo at a backyard barbecue. The theater’s walk-up food window is serving pizza-inspired baked potatoes, a colored chocolate pretzel meant to mimic an asparagus pretzel wand, and more.

There’s also a place to race some “barky boats.” In the show, barky boats is a game that takes place on a tiny stream with tree bark, but there’s no water here. Instead, look for a track in a nook above the seating area, where one can race wooden blocks affixed with wheels — think pinewood derby — down a track painted to mimic a waterway. Throughout the theater, the colors are springlike and muted, pastels that are lightly bright and storybook-inspired. Even the dance costumes adopt this soft, crayon-like color palette.

“The color palette works perfectly with the set,” says Trevor Rush, a manager with costume design and development. “Lots of pastel colors. ‘Bluey,’ that world, focuses very much in that primary world. You won’t see a lot of black represented.”

“Bluey’s Best Day Ever!” does not have an end date, but is expected to be a Disneyland staple through the spring and summer seasons, with showtimes set for the late morning and early afternoons. For Tubert, who has an extensive background in theater, “Bluey’s Best Day Ever!” is meant to highlight the theme park as a place of play, where one can be a bit silly, and maybe even a little vulnerable.

“There’s a nonjudgmental safe space that we’ve created in ‘Bluey’s Best Day Ever!’ that invites everyone to feel uninhibited and the joy of playfulness,” Tubert says.

No signs of stopping for ‘NCIS’ as it hits 500 episodes

[**‘NCIS,’** from E1]
milestone is a worthwhile story in and of itself.

In April 2003, CBS’ popular Navy procedural drama series “JAG” was used as a backdoor pilot to introduce a team of highly skilled special agents from the Naval Criminal Investigative Service, led by no-nonsense supervisory special agent Leroy Jethro Gibbs (Mark Harmon). Working under Gibbs was snappy special agent Anthony DiNozzo (Michael Weatherly), quirky forensics specialist Abby Sciuto (Pauley Perrette) and endearing chief medical examiner Dr. Donald “Ducky” Mallard (David McCallum).

“NCIS” premiered Sept. 23, 2003, with Gibbs, DiNozzo, Abby and Ducky, as well as special agent Caitlin Todd (Sasha Alexander) joining the Washington, D.C., team. However, the series didn’t burst out of the gate as the juggernaut hit it would become. Instead, its freshman season ranked an unspectacular No. 26 among all 2003-04 prime-time broadcast programs, but it was enough to keep it on the air as the audience slowly started to grow. By Season 3, the series was regularly landing in the top 20. And by Season 6, it grew into a solid top five show, and finally, in Season 10, “NCIS” was the No. 1 broadcast series on television.

It’s become a huge international hit, licensed in over 200 territories around the world, subtitled in 35 languages, dubbed in 12 languages. “NCIS” is now the No. 1 TV franchise globally in terms of total minutes viewed.

Additionally, the series has spawned numerous spinoffs, set in Los Angeles, New Orleans and Hawaii, as well as one focused on fan-favorite characters Tony and Ziva David (Cote de Pablo). Currently airing is a prequel series, “NCIS: Origins,” which follows a younger Gibbs (Austin Stowell, with Harmon narrating) in his early NCIS days, and the franchise’s first international spinoff, “NCIS: Sydney,” streaming on Paramount+.

Clearly, “NCIS” has hit on a winning formula resulting in enduring success and one of the factors for that, according to David Stapf, president, CBS Television Studios, is comfort. “You know what you’re going to get and it feels good and you love it so you get that weekly dose or, nowadays, a daily dose because it’s everywhere,” he says.

And in an era when time slots aren’t as do or die for a broadcast series’ success, the fact that, except from 2021 to 2025, “NCIS” has consistently aired on CBS Tuesdays at 8 p.m., shouldn’t be dismissed. “I am a believer that time slots matter, but viewers will watch the show everywhere,” says Amy Reisenbach, president, CBS Entertainment. “They watch it on linear and they watch it on Paramount+, where it’s consistently been a top streaming performer.”

ROBERT VOETS CBS

THE CURRENT cast of “NCIS” features Gary Cole, from left, Katrina Law, Wilmer Valderrama and Sean Murray. Tuesday’s 500th episode will place the series among the longest-running in prime time television.

Life without Gibbs

Like any long-running series, cast members come and go, and those departures can sometimes alter a show’s future. “NCIS,” however, has weathered a myriad of cast changes and the audience continues to come back.

The best example is when Harmon decided to step down in 2021 — Gibbs decided a life fly fishing in Alaska was more his speed. But it was nearly impossible to conceive of “NCIS” without Gibbs or Harmon (who continues as an executive producer). What would the future hold for the show and franchise?

“It’s honest to say that losing Mark Harmon was definitely a little nerve-racking,” says Reisenbach. “He had been with the show since the beginning and had been so synonymous with the show but ... the DNA has remained the same.”

Adds Stapf, “It’s a testament to the writers as well but you’re always nervous on a show that’s working when you change one little aspect because it is that alchemy that makes this show work.” He credits the writers for bringing in new, fleshed-out characters that do more than fill gaps on the team. For example, once the steely Gibbs was gone, Gary Cole’s special agent Alden Parker was markedly different with his laid-back leader vibes and quirky hobbies such as talking true crime and mixing cocktails on his online show.

But Gibbs hasn’t been relegated to the past and his name still comes up occasionally, including in the 500th episode case, though getting there for Binder was a journey. “On the case side of things, I wanted something that encompassed the totality of the show,” he says. However, having revisited a case from the show’s very first episode, “Yankee White,” for a 2024 celebration of the franchise’s 1,000 episodes, that idea was out. “So, I thought, ‘Well, can we go back to episode number two?’ ”

The answer was yes and this week’s installment nods to that 2003 episode. The team meets up with a desperate young man named Billy Fuentes (Austin Marques), a Marine’s son, who as a boy, Gibbs promised that NCIS would always be there for him if he ever needed them. “We even got the same actor, which was great,” says Binder.

Though the case is connected to the past and some Easter eggs pop up, don’t expect it to be a lighthearted greatest hits episode. “This is an event episode and one that’s going to change the DNA of the show and how the show operates from here on out until we’re done,” says Brian Dietzen, who has played chief medical examiner Dr. Jimmy Palmer since the first season.

Part of the big event began at the end of last week’s episode, when a stunned NCIS director Leon Vance (Rocky Carroll) tells Parker that NCIS is being shut down. Tuesday’s episode picks up that thread with the future of the team in jeopardy and plays out differently from the “NCIS” norm.

“I thought it might be nice to play with the format a little bit, and that just gives the episode some energy,” teases Binder. “You have to keep it fresh and keep it new, but you always have to keep it within the same vein so that the next episode won’t be vastly different,” says Dietzen. “As an actor, it’s a challenge to do, but it’s a challenge that’s a really fun one to accept.”

Distinct procedural

A huge component of “NCIS” that has remained consistent from day one is that it’s more than a case-of-the-week procedural. “We have a character-driven procedural which, when we started, this kind of a show was not really a thing,” says Sean Murray, who has played special agent Timothy McGee since the first season. The actor cites how fans loved learning years ago that McGee was also moonlighting as a writer of the fictional “Deep Six” novels that feature heroic characters loosely based on the NCIS team (think Tibbs instead of Gibbs, for example).

Carroll, who has played Vance since the show’s fifth season, admits he didn’t think he’d be in the character’s shoes too long given most shows don’t last as long as “NCIS” has. He signed onto the show partly to reunite with Harmon, whom he previously worked with on the CBS medical drama “Chicago Hope.” “I literally thought to myself, ‘Well, I made it to the tail end of the series. If it goes seven or eight seasons, I’ll get two or three seasons out of it,’ ” he says, adding with a grin. “That was 18 seasons ago.”

And while the original main cast that started on “JAG” so many years ago is long gone (though they occasionally turn up for an episode or two), newer cast members have now become the vets. For example, Wilmer Valderrama joined in Season 14 as special agent Nick Torres, Diona Reasonover’s forensics scientist Kasie Hines joined in Season 15 and at the end of Season 18, Katrina Law first appeared as special agent Jessica Knight.

For Valderrama, he had initial reservations about joining the series and questioned what he could bring to such an established show. “It was in that first meeting where I realized very quickly that what ‘NCIS’ does really well is that it evolves with the times and with its audience,” the actor says. “I realized there was an opportunity there to do something very unique, to light the screen with different colors that I hadn’t painted with before.”

Reasonover had the arduous task of replacing fan favorite Perrette, who left the show after 15 seasons in 2018. Like Carroll, a long-running gig was the last thing on her mind when she began playing the energetic, joyful Kasie. “I didn’t know if [the producers] just wanted to have a quick blip of somebody else [to fill Abby’s forensics role] and then move on to someone different,” she says.

But that turned out not to be the case. And in another example of the show reflecting the times, Reasonover is proud of the fact that the “NCIS” universe has had several queer characters including Kasie. “It’s so nice because it just feels like real life and I always think that that’s what people relate to,” she says.

Thanks to his breakout role as Fez on “That ’70s Show,” Valderrama was already well-known before joining “NCIS” and he’s noticed which role fans recognize him for has changed. “At the end of this season, I will have made 200 episodes of ‘NCIS’ and I did 200 of ‘That ’70s Show,’ ” he says. “I would say it’s like 57% Torres, but I still get Fez a lot since so many people grew up with that guy.”

Since neither the love from fans nor the ratings are diminishing for “NCIS,” which was renewed in January for a 24th season along with “Origins” and “Sydney,” is the universe done expanding or could we get more spinoffs?

“The door is always going to be open because we know how successful ‘NCIS’ is and that the fans have continued to enjoy new iterations,” Reisenbach says.